

Toil

Omeprazole? I prefer toad. Dupixent? I *much* prefer wing of bat. What now? A P-P-I? You think I don't know, know that PPIs carry Omeprazole too. I got a bone to pick with you now, boy. I don't care doctor or king: you don't have licensure for talking down on me. You know why I talk of toad and batwing? Of course not. I know your language; you know none of mine.

The woman pointed out the window. They both understood she meant the moon.

That one out there, you know she's talking to you, yeah? She's talking directly to you and you're here talking to me instead. And more than that, you live in a world where listening is free and dancing is encouraged. Yet you talk to me and ask me to do your feckin *homework*. Goodness gracious, I said bone in the singular but goodness me oh my, you need to pick a hand and point to the specific bone that's botherin you because I certainly can't pick of the many to choose from.

You're a jokester now, huh. Picking your wedding ring finger. Tell me, doc: which phalange are you calling on, really? Because I'm fixing to call a phalanx of my very own fist if you don't choose wisely and banish the humor from your face or from your selection.

You're sticking. Alright. Tell the crystal ball that, too. Motherfeckin feck. Forget it. She heard everything anyway, it's fine. The red cushion means she's recording, so we're fine. Be clear about your comfort going forward, please. I don't need my crystal ball or the fortune cookie box icing me out because you're a little too big for those irreverence britches of yours.

So. Tell me. Why the brace? Knife stuck you and now your palm is numb and so is your wedding ring finger. Well shucks now I feel like an I-don't-know-what. As little respect you've shown, I'll do you the courtesy of assuming you've covered the physical and medical bases already which would be why you're here, presenting in my ER. Alright, fine, great.

No yeah the crystal, she's recording. You'll see something or other appear in her mist sometime soon. The beauty of that there crystal is amnesia. She absorbs and allows the synthesis to float on her cloudy interior, eventually, but she never keeps anything. Really.

Doc, doc. Slow down... You're, oh. You've carried that. I see. And now you're confronting this new loss and you're realizing. Ah. Keep going then. You want some tea? I got a dog who'll keep you company while you speak that truth of yours into those crystal clouds. Name's Kaye. He's a good feller and he'll look after you. And... I want you to know, that... that thing—those things you've said so far, in my earshot at least, I want you to know that you're alright. You always will be, even in the throes of life's pains and ills and whatnot. Don't let that wedding ring finger get dusty. What do I mean by that, doc? Yes, that's

right. Set yourself up for opportunity to knock. No more, no less. But you know what else, that there pup is going to look after you now.

Why'd I say that thing about the throes of life? Here's the tea. Yeah well you already know and you're asking for me to check your work now and that's fine by me. I heard you earlier and I know. I can't speak for you, but I know you've got yourself a certain kind of heart, or a certain kind of soul. And that soul is... you've broken down and you've broken others down and you'll break down again, but I know that when you look back on those memories, you always knew that they were generative and destructive and healing. Those memories, particularly the ones of your own breakage, those: I know you know this doc, but you need to hear it. Which is why you've been so goddamn quiet. What I'm getting at, is that you. Yes you. Even you, when you break down, you allow it in. The damage isn't on your skin. Not in your nerves. Not in your bones. No. It's down to that root of yours. And that's what brought you to me. You knew a worker was needed. Because some breaks need guiding. Need casts. Need wraps. Need an extra set of hands. Need someone who understands that all of us are beautiful and all of us have a toiling, boiling cauldron in us. Always needing to be fed. You know why toads and bats?

They cross worlds. Water, land. Night, day. You've got a little of us on you know. And you've got Kaye, too. He'll watch over you. How do I know? Well, doc, I know from that flood of words you gave the crystal. You had a dog and he's visited you too. Kaye is my dog and he's also mine to share, to bestow on those capable of comprehending him. I don't know what exactly happened and how, but I know that you're on the other side of it now, with me. With us.

Now, doc. Before you leave. Look at the crystal. She's got someone there, in her cloudy hands.

That's you. I saw you when you walked in. The crystal had rain clouds for half an hour before you did. And there you come, no wonder it was clear when you first saw it. Those clouds snapped onto you like white on rice or those metal shavings on that dopey man in the toy. Either way, doc: "after you leave" is now the big question. And that's homework I can't begin. Only you. Yes you can come back. Bring three cigars. Rum. Candy.

No longer recording. But what's this. Black cushion now. Boy. You got a long way to go if that's what I think it means. Ahead or behind, I can't say, but you got something fierce and fiery and hot coming to you. You know you have Kaye. And you know you're alright with me. Pray the way you pray and you know I don't care if you have to decide how you like to. I just need you to. For your own safety. I'll deal with the red and black for you. You, come to think of it, may not even realize it's come and gone with my help. Thank you for bringing those Lunatic cigars. Three was the right amount. You did more research than I treated you for, was mostly yanking your leg with the ribbing and the theatrics. Don't worry about it none. I'll take care. I'll take care. Bye, now.